



I HAVE A DREAM

THE MARCH ON WASHINGTON (1963)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Civil rights movement

BEFORE

1909 National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP) is founded.

1955 Rosa Parks refuses to give up her bus seat to a white man and, in doing so, ignites the civil rights movement.

1960 Four students at a whites-only restaurant counter are refused food, leading to sit-ins across the US.

AFTER

1965 Malcolm X, founder of the Organization of Afro-American Unity, is shot dead.

1966 Stokely Carmichael introduces the idea of “Black Power,” turning away from nonviolent protests.

1968 Martin Luther King, Jr., is assassinated, leading to rioting across US cities.

The March on Washington on August 28, 1963, brought roughly 250,000 people—mostly African Americans—to the nation’s capital. They were calling for equality, an end to racial segregation, and for all Americans to have access to a good education, decent housing, and jobs that paid a living wage.

“There are those who say to you, we are rushing this issue of civil rights. I say we are 172 years too late!

Hubert Humphrey

Mayor of Minneapolis (1948)”

One of the speakers was the Reverend Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., who had been arrested that April during anti-segregation protests in Alabama. “I have a dream,” King cried, starting his famous speech.

Calls for equality

The abolishment of slavery after the American Civil War of 1861–1865 led to formerly enslaved people seeking American citizenship. However, while they were no longer enslaved, they were not equal with whites, and they endured discrimination, segregation, and violent racist attacks. In the 1950s, a number of African American groups fought back against discrimination with a policy of nonviolence. In the 1960s, civil rights marches in Birmingham, Alabama, led by King were central to the campaign. Some extremists, especially in the South, reacted with gruesome acts of violence.

After the March on Washington, US Congress passed the Civil Rights Acts of 1964, outlawing discrimination, and the Voting Rights Act of 1965. More than half a century later, however, many of the goals set on that day are still out of reach to black Americans. ■